

EUROPEAN SWORDS

The sword was the medieval European warrior's most valued weapon. Magnificent blades were often handed down through the generations. Swords were also a symbol of the status and prestige of a knight – a man was made a knight by being dubbed on the shoulders with a sword. Early medieval swords were designed as hacking and slashing weapons to break the mail armour prevalent up to the mid-13th century. But between 1275 and 1350, a transition occurred, with the development of sharply pointed thrusting swords with longer blades better adapted to dealing with plate armour.



▲ GERMAN ULFBERHT SWORD

Date c.900CE

Origin Northern Europe

Length 76cm (30in)

Around 900CE, a new type of sword emerged, as long as its Celtic predecessors but tapering more sharply, with a balance point closer to the hilt. Some weapons of this type are known as Ulfberht swords, from the name of the swordsmith inscribed on many of the blades.

▲ EAST EUROPEAN SABRE

Date 9th–10th century CE

Origin Eastern Europe

Length 95cm (37½in)

Early Eastern European cavalry swords typically had a single-edged blade and a double-edged point, making them suitable for both slashing and thrusting. This example has a sunburst motif on the blade, and the quillons are short with rectangular arms.

► FRENCH CORONATION SWORD AND SHEATH

Date 12th century CE

Origin France

Length 1.05m (3½ft)

This composite sword is traditionally said to have been "Joyeuse", the sword of Charlemagne, although it was first recorded as the coronation sword of Philip the Bold in 1271.

▼ ENGLISH SWORD

Date 14th century CE

Origin England

Weight 760g (27¼oz)

Length 1.04m (3½ft)

The long, double-edged, tapering blade of this sword incorporated a shallow fuller for two-thirds of its length. It has a notably short tang, a small wheel-shaped pommel, and slightly down-curved quillons.